India “at the mercy of the power which controls the mountains.”[4]

China’s war on India in 1962 and its actions threatening intervention in the 1965 India–Pakistan War intensified Indian apprehensions. Conveying these to her British counterpart Edward Heath in October 1970, Prime Minister Indira Gandhi noted that the “threat from China” included the eventuality of China joining a war initiated by Pakistan.[5] This led India to conclude an alliance with the Soviet Union, in which the two countries agreed to consult each other if either came under attack “in order to remove such threat and to take appropriate effective measures to ensure peace and security of their countries.”[6] When, however, Sino–Soviet antagonism began to lessen and Beijing and Moscow began to normalise their relationship in the latter half of the 1980s, the Ministry of Defence articulated Indian concerns regarding China’s consequent ability to redeploy its forces “from the Sino–Soviet border to Tibet,” thus further enhancing its already-improved military position there.[7]

In subsequent years, Indian concerns about China expanded to include China’s assistance for Pakistan’s nuclear weapon and missile programmes, its cross-border strategic infrastructure projects and deepening linkages with India’s continental and maritime neighbours, and the modernisation of the Chinese armed forces. Consequently, even as India sought to improve bilateral relations in the uncertain environment of the post–Cold War years, it continued to view as relevant factors the power projection capabilities of the People’s Liberation Army Air Force (PLAAF) and Navy (PLAN), China’s construction of “strategic road links … to rail-heads and sea ports of Myanmar,” and its “extensive defence collaboration with Pakistan,” including in the nuclear and missile domains.[8] The last of these issues, China’s assistance for Pakistan’s nuclear weapons and missile programmes, was subsequently